

Virginia Woolf

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Virginia Woolf had a very short connection with Fleet Street. Best known as a member of the “Bloomsbury Group”, she was one of the most important 20th century authors. Her novels are written in a stream-of-consciousness style, including *Mrs. Dalloway* (1925) and *To The Lighthouse* (1927). She was born in 1882, the daughter of Leslie Stephen, editor of the *Dictionary of National Biography*, and Julia Duckworth.

In 1912 Virginia married Leonard Woolf. At the time of her marriage, she was living at 38 Brunswick Square in Bloomsbury. Her brother Adrian lived on one floor, she on another, with Maynard Keynes and Duncan Grant sharing the ground floor. Leonard had a room on the fourth floor. The arrangement was considered scandalous. After their honeymoon, Virginia and Leonard moved into rooms in Cliffords Inn, off Fleet Street, a decayed Inn of Chancery.

Virginia was a great letter-writer and kept a diary for most of her life, giving a fascinating glimpse of their lives as a young married couple. They were an unusual couple, with a wide circle of friends and invitations to stay in the country. Quentin Bell, Virginia’s nephew and biographer, comments that the move to Cliffords Inn gave the couple more time together, away from Bloomsbury, and more time for work. Both Virginia and Leonard were writing.

Leonard was also engaged in politics and working part-time at the Grafton Gallery where Roger Fry’s post-impressionist exhibition of Matisse and Picasso had mixed reactions from the public.

Virginia wrote from 13 Cliffords Inn to Katherine Cox in November 1912:

“Dear Bruin,

As you can imagine, it took me about 20 minutes to discover your note, and then look on the floor. When I did I was in a state of keen joy, - and at once fastened the embroideries first to a table, then a sofa, finally to our two armchairs. Desmond [MacCarthy] chanced to come in, I put him against the purple one; Leonard has the one with the green border. I never saw two more handsome men. They are lovely - the embroideries, and in the daylight they will be better still. My life as you know is one long agony of emulation and envy, and I’ve already had the joy of hearing my rooms praised very highly, more highly than Nessa’s; on account of your present. I came in tonight two minutes I daresay after you went waddling across London with about 6 parcels, 3 mutton cutlets, eggs, a cake, and a pound of potatoes. We had dinner in tonight off these. Karin came to lunch, old Cousins half way through the afternoon, so I was late going out, and thus missed Bru Cox; but she might name another day. Our servant shows extreme merit in not minding the sight of us naked which she has every morning.”

From 13 Cliffords Inn on 17 May 1913 to Lady Robert Cecil:

“My dear Nelly,

It’s very bad luck but we are going to Asham today. Perhaps you will ask us another time, at least which is what we hope. But please come to tea again. I’ve just got some new curtains and rearranged the room, said to be a great improvement. The gentleman opposite has just got up in his pyjamas and fed his canary while that art student in the garret has got about 20 pigeons sitting on the sill. Yr V.W.”

Later that year Virginia had a recurrence of her mental illness with extremes of depression and violent excitement. It was decided to give up the rooms in Cliffords Inn. They stored their furniture and books and eventually settled in Richmond at Hogarth House.